

FIGHTING SPIRIT
Iranians protest the Israel-US strikes, in Tehran, June 22

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with Reza in Shiraz. It began with a partial internet blackout. WhatsApp messages stalled, videos failed to load, and Telegram slowed to a crawl. The sense of isolation was immediate and visceral. That evening, military installations outside the city were bombed, the reverberations loud enough to keep anyone awake. And yet, by morning, the city was bustling again. Locals headed to college or work; rickety European cars, mainly the ubiquitous Peugeots, jammed the streets; and women—perfectly groomed, confident and stylish despite the state-mandated hijabs—shopped for rose water and saffron-infused sugar candies.

In the two weeks I spent across Tehran, Kashan, Isfahan, Shiraz, Yazd and Mashhad, I didn't meet a single person who admitted to being afraid of war. In fact, many voiced support for retaliatory strikes on Israel. At the same time, there was a perceptible dislike for the Ayatollah's regime, which many blamed for Iran's faltering economy and for the clerics' dogmatic interference in their way of life. "We all hate our government," said Mehrdad (*name changed*), an urban planner in Isfahan. "A change would be good. But we don't want Israel or the US to interfere."

However, if you were looking for any sign of overt despair, there was none. In the wee hours of June 22, the call to prayer continued uninterrupted at the Imam Reza shrine in Mashhad, a pilgrimage city in the northeast, even as reports emerged of US bombs striking nuclear sites in Isfahan, Fordow and Natanz. Even at that hour, Mashhad's restaurants were serving steaming kebabs and local shoppers haggled animatedly. It was business as usual.

As an Indian, I was met with unexpected warmth and familiarity—taxi fares quietly waived, café bills refused—with many locals expressing a kind of embarrassed sympathy for the hardship their war had brought upon us. "Hindostani!" people would call out warmly, and Bollywood stars, notably Amitabh Bachchan, Shah Rukh Khan and Hema Malini, were frequently invoked in conversations. More surprising was the number of Indian students I encountered, particularly Kashmiri youth studying medicine. "We feel safe here," said Rubina, a second-year MBBS student at Shiraz University, dressed in a pair of jeans, a casual T-shirt and the customary headscarf. But as evacuation began, many of them were forced to abandon their studies and leave behind months, if not years, of effort and hope.

What had begun for me as an art and architecture-themed study tour of four cities in Iran ended in the drama, disruption and anxiety of a war that had made the world hold its breath. There was relief at the commendable success of the Indian embassy in organising our evacuation from Mashhad, within hours of the US strikes. As Mahan Air's Boeing 747 touched down in New Delhi, the cabin filled with a chorus of emotions—Punjabi cries of "*Jo bole so nihal*", Kashmiri chants of "*Ya Ali*", and the soft murmur of the Gayatri Mantra from Gujaratis. In that moment, I was reminded not just of the tremors of war we had left behind in Iran, but of the unshakeable grace with which its people live through them. Dignity, defiance, hope—each took flight with us. ■